Key terms

United Nations Security Council The most important body in the UN, it can take action against a country either by imposing sanctions or by using UN troops.

Trade sanctions A form of punishment where the UN bans a country from trading with other countries in order to force it to obey a UN resolution.

In 1990, when oil prices on the world market dropped steeply, Saddam blamed Kuwait (and the United Arab Emirates) for deliberately causing the fall in prices by overproduction. He accused the Kuwaitis of doing this in order to undermine the Iraqi economy. He was also angry that Kuwait was pressing Iraq to repay the $14 billion it had lent to Iraq during the war with Iran. Saddam stressed that the Iraqi people had made huge sacrifices, in fighting Iran, thus protecting countries like Kuwait. Many Iraqis felt the same way: they felt that they had suffered in order to protect an ungrateful Arab world against the threat of Iranian expansionism. One Iraqi student said:

> The Kuwaitis boast of their aid to Iraq [during the war against Iran], but it was Iraq that defended their thrones and wealth with blood. We sacrificed our brothers, fathers and sons to let them enjoy life.

Saddam now demanded that Kuwait's border with Iraq should be adjusted and that Kuwait should make a further large loan to Iraq. He also accused Kuwait of drilling below the border with Iraq in order to extract huge oil deposits which Iraq claimed as its own.

Key question
What was the international response to Saddam's invasion?

Saddam's invasion of Kuwait, August 1990

Key date

Iraqi invasion of Kuwait: August 1990

With rising discontent at home and a military crisis on his hands, Saddam decided to invade Kuwait. In August 1990 a huge force of 300,000 crossed into Kuwait and overran the country. It took just three days and the rest of the world was completely surprised. However, the international reaction was almost unanimous. The **United Nations Security Council** agreed on complete **trade sanctions** against Iraq: no country was to have any trade with Iraq until their forces had withdrawn from Kuwait. These were the most complete and effective sanctions ever imposed by the UN.

Saddam, however, was defiant. He even announced that Kuwait had been annexed and become a province of Iraq. He also tried to win Arab support by saying that he would withdraw Iraqi forces only when the Israelis withdrew *their* forces from the West Bank and Gaza. The Palestinians were thrilled and many in Jordan were sympathetic but the majority of Arab states were united in condemning Iraq. When Saddam ordered the detention of hundreds of foreigners as hostages, mostly Westerners caught in Iraq or Kuwait, there was outrage. Some of the hostages were used as human shields by being kept near to military targets. Although the women and children, the sick and the old were soon released, there was still widespread condemnation of Iraqi behaviour. Then news emerged of atrocities committed by Iraqi troops on Kuwaiti citizens.

No one was more horrified at the Iraqi invasion of Kuwait than the Americans. As long ago as 1957, US President Eisenhower had written to one of his advisers: 'Should a crisis arise threatening to cut the Western world off from the Mid East oil, we would *have* to use force.'